

internet), a delivery method (a browser) and an end-user, and the job of the web designer is to create content, deliver it and run usability and readability checks to ensure that everything runs the way it is intended to.

Starting with the basics

There are prerequisites to becoming a web designer. Since this is a knowledge intensive job, you need to have sound knowledge of mark-up languages such as HTML, XHTML and XML; stylesheet languages such as CSS and XSL; client-side scripting such as JavaScript; server-side scripting such as PHP and ASP; database technologies such as MySQL and PostgreSQL; graphics design tools like Adobe Photoshop, Adobe Illustrator and Adobe InDesign; and multimedia technologies like Flash and Silverlight. If these terms sound overwhelming, you probably haven't taken your first steps into the coding world just yet. Don't worry; start small with basics like HTML. Later you can specialise in one or more amongst these based on what interests you. Although it does help to have broad-based knowledge – it's what separates an average designer from the pros. Tenacity and an eye for detail are also key to success.

You may wonder “How is web designing different from programming and graphics designing?” Graphics design is a much wider field and is not limited to the web. When applied solely to the web, graphics designing is the part that forms the visual aspects of the site; whereas web programming involves writing the code that lends the website the functionality that makes the design work. A web designer has knowledge of both, programming and graphics designing. The job profile also depends on the size and structure of the company that you work in. In smaller companies, everyone does a little bit of everything – the work is shared and overlaps amongst people.

A day in the life of a Web Designer

A typical day starts with the designer sitting down with clients for a thorough need-analysis. This is where communication and assimilation skills come in handy; after all, a job well understood is a job half done. In most cases, the client will provide you with required inputs such as text, imagery, logo, fonts and pictures; there are exceptions where the designer is asked to create these aspects too.

G. Sai Nihlas, who works as a freelancer for 3SixtyFive, a social media and branding firm, sums up his typical day like this: “on an average I work for about 7-8 hours, and I use Adobe Photoshop CS5, Adobe Illustrator CS5 and